breakouts, allergic reactions, hormonal imbalance and even organ complications, not to mention serious risks like HIV or hepatitis. Bollywood actress Shefali Jariwala allegedly received an IV drip before suffering cardiac arrest in 2025. "IV infusions are medical treatments, not cosmetic trends," says Dr Shweta Nakhawa, consultant dermatologist, KIMS Hospitals, Thane.

Thirty-six-year-old Simran Kaur Bedi discovered this the hard way. About to get married, she walked into a sleek wellness lounge in Mumbai earlier this month, lured by their 'bridal cocktail' IV drip package. She was given an infusion rich in vitamins, antioxidants and minerals like glutathione and vitamin C that promised a wedding-ready radiance. "It felt clinical, but they made it sound like a luxury beauty ritual," Simran says. Within three weeks, she began noticing painful acne flaring up along her jawline and cheeks. With her wedding only weeks away, Simran decided to postpone the ceremony.

When a needle punctures the skin, there's a risk of infection or vein irritation. More serious risks include air embolism, blood clots, or allergic reactions. "Administering high doses of vitamins and minerals without proper assessment can lead to nutrient overload or electrolyte imbalances, which can be harmful, especially for those with kidney or heart conditions," says Chawla.

Of course, many clinics are taking care to ensure safety. "Patient safety and clinical hygiene are non-negotiable. Every IV drip therapy is administered under strict medical protocols in a clean, sterile environment," says Zaverie. She adds that all IV drips are prescribed and supervised by a certified medical doctor. They also follow up with clients to check on their wellbeing after the session.

However, some IV clinics operate in poorly ventilated rooms, reuse gloves, or lack proper sterilisation protocols for needles and IV lines. Common mistakes include using expired fluids, improper storage of vitamins, mislabelled ingredients and mixing unapproved substances without medical oversight.

THE VITAMIN COCKTAIL MENU*

- **The Immunity Booster:** Vitamin C, zinc, anti-antioxidants for immune defense, fighting fatigue
  Cost: Rs 4,500-Rs 8,000
- **Glow Drip:** Packed with the antioxidant glutathione and vitamin C for glowing skin
  Cost: Rs 8,000-Rs 15,000
- **The Hangover Cure:** Rehydrates with electrolytes, B-vitamins, anti-nausea meds—bye to last night's addled brain
  Rs 3,000-Rs 10,000
- **Jet Lag Relief:** A mix of Vitamin B12, magnesium and fluids to reset your energy
  Cost: Rs 3,000-Rs 10,000
- **The Beauty Bag**: Collagen, biotin, and vitamins for stronger hair, glowing skin
  Cost: Rs 4,000-Rs 20,000
- **Weight Drip**: L-carnitine, MIC (methionine, inositol, choline), B-vitamins, and optional glutathione; marketed for fat burn
  Rs 3,000-Rs 15,000
- **Forever Young Drip**: Antioxidants, vitamins and amino acids aimed at anti-aging
  Rs 10,000-Rs 65,000

**Prices differ based on clinic and quality/quantity of ingredients used*

Limits to IV Therapy

The risks get worse when IV drips are used to manage chronic conditions without clinical evidence. "I watch the growing trend around IV drips for weight loss, often promising quick results, with worry. No intravenous medicine has received approval for weight loss," says Dr Ramen Goel, consultant at Wockhardt Hospitals. "Any weight drop may be due to fluid shifts, not fat loss. Weight loss is a complex process that involves managing calories, balancing hormones, metabolism and lifestyle. No infusion can change these factors," he adds.

At the heart of these IV drips are antioxidants like vitamin C, glutathione and alpha-lipoic acid, believed to fight free radicals (molecules that damage cells and cause various diseases) and reduce cellular damage. While antioxidants are essential nutrients found naturally in food, the doses delivered through IV therapy can be hundreds of times higher. A 100 gm orange, for example, contains 53.2 mg of Vitamin C, while IV clinics offer doses between 10,000-50,000 mg a day. Clinics offering these drips argue that flooding the bloodstream with antioxidants boosts the immune system, supports detoxification and helps fight disease better, including cancerous cells. Experts, though, warn that such high doses can do more harm, especially when taken in place of evidence-based treatments. As happened in the case of Amit Vashisht, a 52-year-old retired banker from Pune, who delayed chemotherapy for colon cancer in favour of high-dose IV therapy. His cancer advanced, and he now regrets it. "I was just buying time I didn't have," he says.

Reproductive health claims are similarly unproven. "There isn't strong evidence that IV vitamin drips improve fertility or treat PCOS (Polycystic Ovary Syndrome)," says Dr Nidhi Rajotia Goel, unit head, Obstetrics & Gynaecology, Artemis Hospital.

Experts agree on the need for stronger oversight. Key recommendations are tighter regulations from Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation and The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) to curb misleading claims, monitoring of brands that alter formulas for off-label use, public advisories on side-effects and action against unlicensed IV clinics.

Dr P. Venkata Krishnan, senior consultant at Artemis Hospital, has the final word. "IV therapy is usually safe when done correctly," he says. "But real wellness still comes from a balanced diet, regular exercise, hydration and enough sleep." Read that as: a cup of broccoli, a nap, and staying off Insta for a day. ■